WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

GUINEA-BISSAU

Africa

Information current as of November 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Bissau	Capital, main seaport and commercial centre; base for government, banks, the BCEAO national directorate and the cashew export trade	Trade and logistics, financial services, construction, services
Cashew-growing interior	Heartland of the country's leading export, which generated 93% of export revenues in 2023 and supported 5.8% GDP growth in 2025	Cashew processing, agri-logistics, storage, agro-industry
Bijagós Archipelago	Guinea-Bissau's first UNESCO World Heritage site (inscribed July 2025), hosting about 50,000 green turtle nests and up to 850,000 migratory birds a year	Eco-tourism, conservation finance, sustainable hospitality
Farim (north)	Site of the construction-ready Farim phosphate project, with 44 million tonnes of reserves and planned output of 1.3 million tonnes a year over 25 years	Mining, fertiliser inputs, mining services and logistics
Atlantic fishing waters	Rich fishing grounds underpinned by an EU partnership protocol (2024–2029) worth €17 million a year, and identified by the IMF as a diversification priority alongside offshore oil	Fisheries, cold chain, seafood processing, offshore exploration
OMVG grid corridor (Antula, Mansoa, Bambadinca, Saltinho)	Four substations linking Guinea-Bissau to the 1,677 km regional loop with The Gambia, Guinea and Senegal, including the 800 MW Antula substation near Bissau inaugurated in 2025	Power distribution, energy services, industrial users

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Investment Code (Law No. 13/2011) guaranteeing equal treatment, protection against expropriation without fair compensation, and recourse to conciliation and ICSID arbitration
- Code incentives for investments of $34,000 or more, including customs and sales-tax exemptions on equipment and corporate-tax reductions for up to seven years; projects of $80 million or more can negotiate an investment contract approved by the Council of Ministers
- Applications lodged with the Ministry of Economy, with the Directorate General for Promotion of Private Investment overseeing incentives; company formation via the Centro de Formalização de Empresas, where fees were halved to 180,000 CFA francs in 2025

- BCEAO and WAEMU monetary framework: the CFA franc is pegged to the euro, and the Investment Code guarantees currency conversion and the transfer abroad of profits, dividends and capital through the banking system
- Bilateral investment treaties, including with Portugal and China, providing additional treaty protection
- Sector-entry routes through the EU fisheries protocol and licensing, mining concessions such as Farim phosphate, and cashew export and processing licences
- Co-financing alongside development partners, including the World Bank's $35 million Solar Energy Scale-up and Access Project and the OMVG regional interconnection

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Guinea-Bissau enters late 2026 with solid growth, low inflation and an established IMF reform track record. Real GDP grew an estimated 5.8% in 2025, driven by a strong cashew harvest, good farmgate prices and private investment, and is projected at 4.8–4.9% in 2026 by the World Bank and IMF. Inflation fell to 0.9% in 2025, and the WAEMU-wide rate was just 1.3% in August 2026, with the BCEAO holding its policy rate at 3.00% in September 2026. The IMF reached staff-level agreement on the eleventh review of its Extended Credit Facility in May 2026, noting that all end-March 2026 targets had been met, with cumulative disbursements of about $52.8 million. FDI inflows remain modest at an estimated $34 million in 2025, leaving early movers room to establish positions in cashew processing, fisheries, renewable energy, mining and eco-tourism.

The country's main structural challenge is concentration: cashew nuts account for about nine-tenths of export revenues, leaving receipts sensitive to prices, weather and freight costs, while around $50 million a campaign is lost to informal cross-border trade. Mitigation is under way. The transitional government held the 2026 producer reference price at 410 CFA francs per kg under a 'zero tolerance' smuggling campaign; the 2024–2029 EU fisheries protocol provides €17 million a year; the OMVG grid and World Bank solar programme are expanding power supply from a 33% national access rate; and the IMF has prioritised diversification into fisheries and extractives such as phosphate and bauxite. Each of these creates a direct opportunity, above all in local processing, which would capture more of the cashew value chain at home.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Political transition and return to constitutional order	A military-led transition has governed since November 2025, and ECOWAS and the African Union have suspended Guinea-Bissau; a new constitution was approved by referendum in August 2026, but the transitional prime minister said in October that the 6 December elections cannot be held as planned	Phase commitments to the electoral timetable, screen counterparties against UN, EU, UK and US lists as standard, and note that IMF engagement and ECOWAS mediation, led by Senegal, have continued throughout
Dependence on cashew exports	Cashew generates about 90% of export revenues, so prices, weather and freight costs drive export income and growth	Local processing and diversification into fisheries, mining and tourism offer the most direct investment upside
Limited fiscal space	Public debt stood at 75.6% of GDP in 2025, above the WAEMU ceiling, with tax revenue at about 8.5% of GDP and a deficit of 6.5% of GDP	The IMF programme is anchoring fiscal reform, and investors can structure projects with DFI co-financing rather than relying on state funding
Electricity access and cost	Only around 33% of the population (58% in Bissau) had electricity access in 2024, raising costs for industry	The OMVG interconnection and World Bank-backed solar programme create openings in generation, distribution and off-grid supply
Access to finance	Bank non-performing loans rose above 22% by mid-2025, constraining local credit	Bring offshore or DFI financing, and draw on regional WAEMU banks and the stable CFA franc for local operations
Institutional predictability	The World Bank cites institutional unpredictability and taxation as leading business constraints	Use Investment Code contracts, bilateral investment treaties and ICSID arbitration clauses, and engage early with officials
Informal cashew trade	Smuggling costs the country close to $50	Traceable, formal supply chains and

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	million per campaign in lost value	partnership with producer groups give compliant buyers and processors an edge

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Guinea-Bissau's risk profile combines sound recent macroeconomic performance with a political transition that investors should follow closely. Growth of 5.8% in 2025, inflation below 1%, membership of the euro-pegged WAEMU currency union and a sustained record of meeting IMF programme targets, including after the change of government, give a stable monetary base. The principal consideration is the return to constitutional order: Guinea-Bissau remains suspended from ECOWAS and the African Union, a new constitution expanding presidential powers was approved in August 2026, and the timing of the presidential and legislative elections set for 6 December 2026 is now under review. ECOWAS has not imposed economic sanctions and has appointed Senegal as facilitator. Investors should take sanctions-screening and governance advice as standard, build election-timing scenarios into plans, and use the Investment Code's arbitration and repatriation guarantees. Those who prepare now will be well placed for the wider re-engagement by partners that typically follows a completed transition.

MARKET ACCESS

Guinea-Bissau is a member of the West African Economic and Monetary Union (WAEMU), sharing the BCEAO-managed CFA franc with seven other states, and of ECOWAS, whose regional market offers wider West African access, although its participation in ECOWAS decision-making bodies is suspended during the transition. It is also a WTO member and part of the Community of Portuguese Language Countries, which supports commercial ties with Portugal, Brazil and the wider Lusophone world. India is by far the largest buyer of its exports, overwhelmingly raw cashew nuts, while Portugal, Senegal and China are leading import sources. The EU fisheries partnership gives European fleets licensed access to Bissau-Guinean waters, and the OMVG interconnection links the country's grid to The Gambia, Guinea and Senegal. Its Atlantic coastline and border with Senegal and Guinea position it as a natural supply point for coastal West Africa.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Transitional Presidency (General Horta N'Tam)	Leads the transition, sets the electoral timetable and is barred from standing in the coming elections under the transitional charter	Primary reference point for transition timing and strategic direction
Prime Minister and Minister of Finance (Ilídio Vieira Té)	Leads economic policy and IMF programme dialogue, and opened the 2026 cashew campaign	Key counterpart for fiscal, tax and cashew-sector matters
Ministry of Economy and Directorate General for Promotion of Private Investment	Receives Investment Code applications and oversees incentive approvals and monitoring	Standard first point of contact for incentives and investment contracts
BCEAO (Central Bank of West African States), national directorate in Bissau	Regional central bank managing the CFA franc, monetary policy and bank supervision	Relevant for currency, transfers and banking matters
ECOWAS and Senegal (appointed facilitator)	Mediating the return to constitutional order and setting the conditions for lifting Guinea-Bissau's suspension	Essential for reading transition milestones and the outlook for normalisation
IMF and World Bank	IMF Extended Credit Facility anchors macro reform; the World Bank funds energy, digital and private-sector programmes	Useful sources of policy insight and potential co-financing
OMVG (Gambia River Basin Development Organisation)	Regional body behind the interconnection bringing hydro power from Kaléta and Sambangalou into the national grid	Relevant for energy, industrial and grid-linked investment

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

Development partners are the most active channels for investors: the World Bank, whose 2026 Economic Update sets out a private-sector growth agenda covering tax simplification, credit access, customs modernisation and the national fibre backbone; the IMF country team; the African Development Bank, which approved a $20.6 million health-sector grant in December 2025; and the regional development bank BOAD, active in port infrastructure. The European Union is a major partner through its fisheries protocol and sectoral support. Portuguese-speaking networks, notably through Portugal, Guinea-Bissau's largest import source, and the Community of Portuguese Language Countries, provide practical market intelligence. In-country, the Centro de Formalização de Empresas and the Ministry of Economy are the main entry points for company set-up and incentives.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Guinea-Bissau best suits patient, risk-aware investors with West African experience: agri-processors and commodity traders able to add value to the cashew crop locally; fisheries and seafood investors building on the EU partnership; renewable-energy and off-grid developers aligned with World Bank and OMVG programmes; mining investors, notably in phosphate; and eco-tourism operators focused on the newly inscribed Bijagós World Heritage site. DFI-backed and impact investors are particularly well placed, and all investors should phase commitments around the completion of the political transition.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Track transition milestones and complete compliance screening
Follow the revised election timetable and ECOWAS mediation, and obtain sanctions-screening and governance advice on counterparties before committing capital.

STEP 2: Engage the Ministry of Economy on Investment Code terms
Clarify incentive eligibility, and for larger projects the scope for an investment contract with arbitration and repatriation guarantees.

STEP 3: Assess the cashew value chain for processing opportunities
Evaluate local processing, storage and traceable sourcing ahead of the next campaign, using the government's reference price and anti-smuggling drive.

STEP 4: Partner with development finance institutions
Explore co-financing and risk-sharing with the World Bank, AfDB, BOAD and EU programmes in energy, fisheries and infrastructure.

STEP 5: Position for diversification sectors
Map opportunities in fisheries, phosphate mining, solar power and Bijagós eco-tourism, ready to scale as constitutional order is restored.